

THE SUN RISES AGAIN

Manmohan-Abe summit leads to progress on security and trade ties, but Tokyo steers clear of the nuclear issue

■ By Saurabh Shukla

The milieu was strikingly familiar as Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe met his Indian counterpart Manmohan Singh for their summit meeting on August 22, their second bilateral meeting within a span of eight months, since they last met in Tokyo in 2006. They knew they had to move beyond declarations as time was ticking off for them. The two prime ministers could draw a common cause given the domestic political storms both find themselves embroiled in. Manmohan is facing one of the toughest challenges for his coalition Government on the Indo-US nuclear deal and Abe is still trying to overcome the shock of his worst-ever rout in the elections of the Diet with the Opposition Democratic Party of Japan wrestling control of the upper house.

Domestic setbacks notwithstanding, the mood was business-like as Abe used his three-day visit to strengthen the Strategic Global Partnership which the two countries had launched last year. "The two countries are going to expand and fortify their relations," Abe said as he outlined his commitment to deepen the bilateral ties in his address to both the houses of Parliament—a rare gesture considering that even US President George W. Bush and Chinese President Hu Jintao, had not been bestowed this honour.

To many observers here the 52-year-old Abe came across as a go-getter bubbling with enthusiasm. He was at ease during the official parleys. Earlier, at a function organised to felicitate him, his artistic skills were at display as he painted a rising sun, his tribute to the booming Indo-Japanese ties. During his talks with the Indian leadership, the Japanese premier pitched for his concept of the Arc of Freedom and Prosperity, and called for



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STRATEGIC PARTNERS: Abe with Manmohan at Rashtrapati Bhavan

broader Asia, a confluence of countries with shared strategic interests, where India and Japan can play an important role. "The strategic global partnership of Japan and India is pivotal," he said.

At the summit meeting, the two sides rolled out a road map on the new

dimensions of strategic cooperation with a security dialogue and big ticket projects like the Delhi-Mumbai freight and industrial corridor. But on the nuclear issue, even though Japan may support the Indo-US nuclear deal at the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG), Abe remained non-committal. In an interview with INDIA TODAY (see box), Abe